There can be no quarrel with the truism that because public employee unions attempt to influence governmental policymaking, their activities—and the views of members who disagree with them—may be properly termed political. But that characterization does not raise the ideas and beliefs of public employees onto a higher plane than the ideas and beliefs of private employees. It is no doubt true that a central purpose of the First Amendment " 'was to protect the free discussion of governmental affairs.' " *Post,* at 259, quoting *Buckley* v. *Valeo,* 424 U. S. 1, 14, and *Mills* v. *Alabama,* 384 U. S. 214, 218. But our cases have never suggested that expression about philosophical, social, artistic, economic, literary, or ethical matters—to take a nonexhaustive list of labels—is not entitled to full First Amendment protection.[28] Union members in both the public and private sectors may find that a variety of union activities conflict with their beliefs. Compare, *e. g.,*

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[28] See, *e. g., Wooley* v. *Maynard,* 430 U. S. 705, 714 (the First Amendment "secures the right to proselytize religious, political, *and ideological* causes") (emphasis supplied); *Young* v. *American Mini Theatres,* 427 U. S. 50, 70 (plurality opinion) (protection of the First Amendment is fully applicable to the communication of social, political, or philosophical messages); *id.,* at 87 (dissenting opinion) (even offensive speech that does not address "important topics" is not less worthy of constitutional protection); *Police Dept. of Chicago* v. *Mosley,* 408 U. S. 92, 95–96; *Cohen* v. *California,* 403 U. S. 15, 25, quoting *Winters* v. *New York,* 333 U. S. 507, 528 (Frankfurter, J., dissenting); *Street* v. *New York,* 394 U. S. 576, 593, quoting *West Virginia Bd. of Ed.* v. *Barnette,* 319 U. S. 624, 641–642 (" '[N]o official, high or petty, can prescribe what shall be orthodox in politics, nationalism, religion, *or other matters of opinion*' ") (emphasis supplied); *NAACP* v. *Button,* 371 U. S. 415, 444–445; *Kingsley Pictures Corp.* v. *Regents,* 360 U. S. 684, 688 (suppression of a motion picture because it expresses the idea that under certain circumstances adultery may be proper behavior strikes at the very heart of First Amendment protection); *NAACP* v. *Alabama ex rel. Patterson,* 357 U. S. 449, 460 ("it is immaterial whether the beliefs sought to be advanced . . . pertain to political, economic, religious, or cultural matters"); *Roth* v. *United States,* 354 U. S. 476, 488, quoting *Thornhill* v. *Alabama,* 310 U. S. 88, 101–102.